

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Everything is in excess. When *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007*'s blushing host Aditya Narayan is kissed by a girl in the audience, guru Ismail Darbar asks her to do it again. When *Indian Idol 3*'s celebrity judge Alisha Chinai finds a singer's performance good, Anu Malik rounds on her with a "What are you talking? *Arre yaar*, she was completely off key." When Darbar says that singers should not be judges, Abhijeet, an excitable judge on the show *Voice of India*, says Bappi Lahiri, another guru on *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*, sings like a girl, upon which Lahiri calls him a third class person. Shock. Horror. Aww. Welcome to the drama-mascara world of reality shows, where minor disagreements are embellished with enough background music to make them sound like national affronts and all exits are squeezed dry for gallons of lachrymose tears. Having lived through seven long soapy years of ear-splitting dialogues and cliff-hanging emotions, the country's talent hunts have become, laughs *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007* celebrity guru Vishal Dadlani, "*saas, bahu* and singers".

The more bizarre the better. Coming up soon is a talent show on the spiritual channel Aastha to find the best religious singer in the country (with a pilgrimage as the top prize) and another on Sahara Filmy called *Bathroom Singer*, where the sets will be modelled on a, yes you guessed it, bathroom. What next? Finest Bedroom Warbler? Or Best Ramdev Disciple?

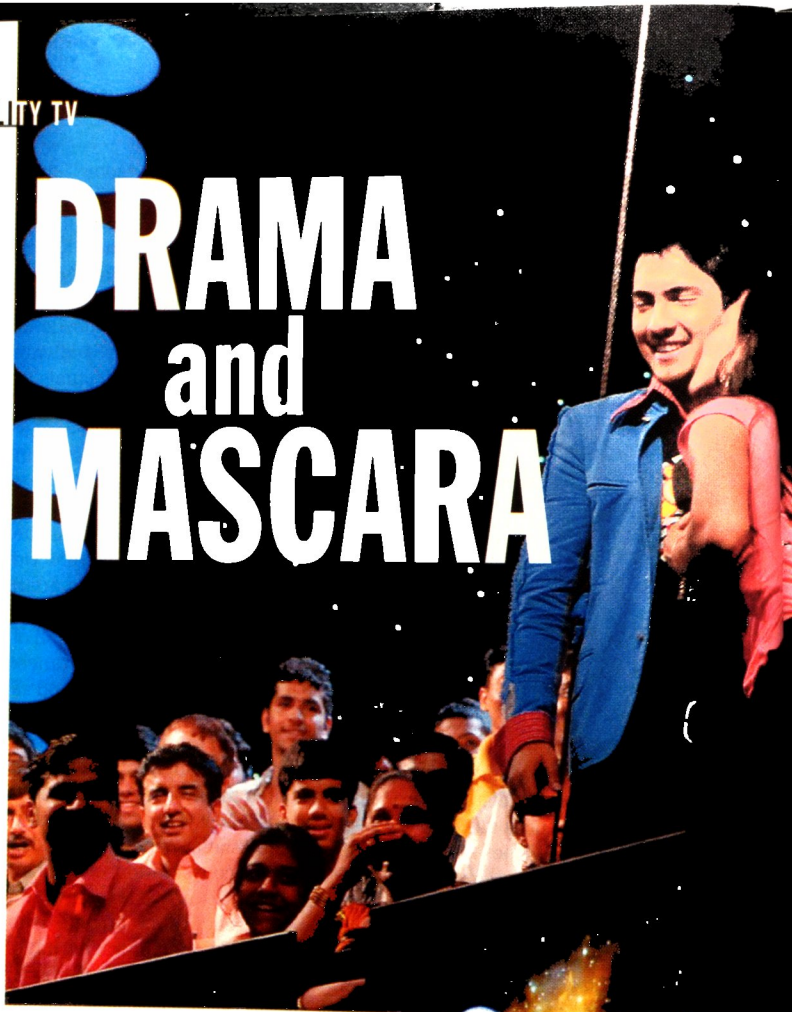
Between 2005 and 2006, viewers spent almost one lakh more minutes on reality shows, a trend not likely to be reversed this year. The ratings of reality shows have started challenging the seemingly invincible soaps—if the average June tip of Zee TV's *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007* is 4.14, that of the highest rated soap, Star Plus' *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*, is 6.66. If the share of the genre itself has not grown (in April-June this year it was 6.67 per cent for reality television and 70.93 per cent for serials), it is only because reality shows are expensive to produce and unpredictable (yes, casting old flames Farah Khan and Akashdeep Saigal may have created a

DRAMA and MASCARA

As reality shows overdose on hissy fits and bilious babble, the ratings finally start to challenge the soaps

flutter in *Jhalak Dikhlaja* last year, but suppose it hadn't?). According to TAM data, those who watch reality shows are younger, better off and usually male. It is, as Sony Executive Vice-President Albert Almeida points out, the audience that doesn't watch weekday soaps.

So as the red carpet fever sweeps the nation, everyone is learning to let fly. Darbar can declare regional contest winners a waste of time, Javed Akhtar can take it upon himself to dance on stage, Malik can start singing like a rocker on speed and Abhijeet, who rarely has a kind word to say to anyone, can call Alka Yagnik an airhead. Contestants are made to swish their made-over hair (Smita Adhikari in **IDOL CHATTER: (From left) Akhtar, Chinai, Udit Narayan and Malik**



REAL DRAMA

Viewer time spent on reality shows

2005: 2,98,369 min

2006: 3,93,702 min

2007: 1,84,366 min and counting

Source: TAM